

reducing contrast. Keeping your filter very clean will help counter reduction in image quality and using high quality UV filters will prevent any visible colour cast. It's often a point of debate whether the protection provided by UV filters outweighs the potential reduction in quality, but when expensive SLR lenses are in question, protection becomes the deciding factor as costs of replacing the filter are far lower than those of possible repair of lens. Another advantage for long-term users is that these filters keep the front lens in mint conditions and thus increase the resale value of lenses.

ND filters

Another useful filter in photography is Neutral Density (ND) filter, which in simple terms is a semi-transparent piece of glass that, when placed in front of the camera lens, obstructs a precisely controlled fraction of light uniformly, without altering image sharpness or contrast. By reducing the amount of light reaching the camera's sensor, they are most commonly used when the given range of possible apertures does not allow for a sufficiently long exposure time. This can emphasise motion, or make an otherwise tumultuous scene appear surreal and tranquil. Alternatively an ND filter also enables larger aperture, leading to sharper photos and shallower depths of field. Either way this is a powerful tool, not given its due appreciation often, but worthy of a deeper look. They are one of the simplest filters to use with results not easily replicable digitally. Neutral Density filters are used to create any, or combinations, of a longer exposure time, a shallower depth of field and a sharper photograph.

Longer exposure times allow you to play around with images for artistic effects, like softening of turbulent water, blurring of grass patches in winds, or emphasising motion within crowds of people. For full effect, multi-second exposures are a must, rendering clouds as streaks in the sky and making waves appear as uniform, low-laying mist. With a lot of experimentation and some sound intuition, related desired effects can be



Neutral Density filter to allow longer exposures